

The Dissertation

This paper is designed to explain some of the main points about undertaking the dissertation on the MBA and MA suite of programmes provided by York St John University and Robert Kennedy College. It sets out the requirements of this stage of the programmes, and provides some guidance, based on past experience. It should be read along with the Dissertation Module Handbook, which provides detailed information about the module requirements and the marking scheme.

The questions this paper addresses are:

What can I research into?
What do I need to produce?
What are the timescales?
How do I enrol on the module? What do I do after I enrol?
How do I work with a supervisor?
What do I need to do in order to succeed on the module?
What happens after I complete the dissertation?

What can I research into?

For this module you are expected to undertake research into a topic related to the degree you are studying, and produce a dissertation. You are expected to gather information in an area of your choice, and analyse it with reference to relevant academic theory. An indication of relevant topics for each of the degrees is shown in Table 1, based on the name of the qualification and on the modules within it. Note that these are broad topic areas, and you will need to develop a more detailed focus for your dissertation.

Degree	Relevant topics for a dissertation
MBA or MA Leading Innovation and Change	Leadership, innovation, change, strategy, culture
MBA Leadership and Management	Leadership, management, coaching, strategy
MBA Entrepreneurship and Innovation	Innovation, change, entrepreneurship, strategy, culture
MBA Coaching, Mentoring, Leadership	Coaching/mentoring, leadership, innovation, change, culture
MBA Innovation, Leadership and Consulting	Innovation, change, leadership, consulting, strategy
MBA Management Consulting	Consulting, innovation, change, strategy, culture

In terms of subject matter, you may focus on an aspect of any one of these relevant topics, or your research may focus on a combination of two or more of the topics. One of the most important characteristics of good quality dissertations is that they have a clear focus, and usually quite a narrow focus, so that including more topics is not necessarily going to make your dissertation better. In practice, you have a great deal of scope for choice, as long as you can relate your research subject to one of the topics relevant to your degree.

You are not expected to develop, challenge or amend any universal theories of any of these topics. The most common outcome will be that you will draw conclusions about how certain theories may (or may not) apply in a particular setting or settings. You may do this by deliberately assessing the extent to which specific theories apply in a chosen situation (a

deductive research approach) or by analysing events in a chosen situation and then comparing your analysis with existing published theory (an inductive research approach). Your chosen situation may be within an organisation, or across two or more organisations, or within a community, or communities.

When deciding on what you will research into, take into account:

- what you are interested in: you will spend several months on this research, and the process will be much more enjoyable if you choose something that interests you.
- course requirements: as you can see. these give you quite a bit of scope for choice.
- practicalities: the topic must be something you can research in the time available. In thinking about this, you need to take into account such factors as: access to respondents and situations, resources available to you, the difficulty and complexity of the potential topic, and your skills in research activities.

The research methodology that you will use for your dissertation is a matter of your choice - but you must be able to justify your decision in relation to your topic and what you are trying to achieve. All methodologies have their strengths and limitations. You may decide to use mainly qualitative methods, and gather all your information from interviews or focus groups, or you may decide that you wish to use quantitative methods and gather information through a questionnaire. Or you may want to do both. The choice is yours, but you must be able to demonstrate that you have made a realistic evaluation of what your chosen methodology can achieve. You will encounter information about methodologies in the residency week, and in the support literature available through the University library.

What do I need to produce?

To complete the module, you must produce two documents for assessment.

1. The Proposal

A written research proposal, submitted prior to carrying out the full research. The proposal should state what you want to find out (the research question and research objectives), provide an overview of the relevant literature, and give an outline of your proposed research methodology. It should be 2,000 words long (with an allowable margin of plus or minus 10%). It accounts for 20% of marks for the module.

2. The Dissertation

The full report, setting out the background to your research, a literature review, an explanation of your methodology, a description of your findings, an analysis of your findings in relation to relevant literature, and conclusions and recommendations. This should be 12,000 words long (with the usual allowable margins). It accounts for the remaining 80% of marks for the module.

There are more details of what each document should contain in the Module Handbook. Read these carefully, as they will be applied by the assessors when they come to mark your work.

When you enrol on the module, you will be given deadlines for the submission of both these pieces of work (see the next section on timescales).

To pass the module, you must achieve 50% or more of the total marks available. It is not compulsory to achieve a pass mark for both pieces of work - you could, for example, fail the Proposal, pass the Dissertation, and still achieve an overall pass mark. You can, however, re-take either piece of work, once, if you fail it - as with all the other assignments on the programme. You must achieve a minimum of 20% in each piece of work.

The Proposal is meant to lay the ground for the research, and for the Dissertation itself. The relationship between the two documents is thus different from the relationship between any of the other assignments on the course. Because of this, you are allowed to use parts of the Proposal directly in the Dissertation, by cutting and pasting, without acknowledging that you have used them in the Proposal document. However, if you wish to use text from any of your other assignments in the Dissertation (or the Proposal), the normal rules apply - you must show that you are quoting text you have already written for a previous piece of work. The Proposal - because it is a preparatory document in the same module - is the only piece of work that you can use in this different way.

In research projects, unexpected events sometimes arise and derail the original plans. You may, for example, complete a proposal, receive a mark for it, and then find that you are unable to carry it out, and that you need to do something completely different. Major changes like this do not happen often - when they do, it is usually because the researcher's access to respondents has unexpectedly become much more difficult or impossible. If this happens to you, you will retain your original mark for the Proposal, even though the Dissertation will no longer carry out your stated plan. You are not expected to develop and submit a new Proposal for assessment, although it is probably a useful exercise to go through the process for your new Dissertation topic, to help with the development of a good project.

What are the timescales?

Timescales for the module apply to you from the time you enrol on the Dissertation module, and the module formally starts. Deadlines for the Proposal and for the Dissertation are set from this point.

The deadline for the Proposal is currently six weeks from the beginning of the module. The deadline for the Dissertation is 30 weeks from the beginning of the module. When you are enrolled on the module, you will be notified of the dates that apply to you for both these pieces of assessed work.

There will be a period of about four weeks after you have submitted the Proposal when you will not know what mark it has achieved. It is important that you keep working on the Dissertation during this period. The Proposal will be going through the normal processes of assessment by RKC tutors and of moderation by University tutors, and it will take four weeks before a mark can be awarded to you. Make sure you work with your supervisor while you are developing your Proposal, and get feedback from them on a draft of it before you submit it. That way, you can be fairly confident you are working on the right lines with the Proposal, and in the weeks immediately after you have submitted it.

How do I enrol on the module? What do I do after I enrol?

After you have completed the Residency week, you may apply to enrol on the Dissertation module. The RKC website will indicate dates when the module will next begin. Use the time during and after the Residency to think about the topic you wish to research, and the

methods you would like to use. Be smart about your enrolment date. Plan it for when you think you will be able to collect the data, and will have a space for the writing up period.

When you enrol for the Residency, you will be enrolled on an online campus module site, where you will be able to use forums to exchange ideas with colleagues from the Residency, and view further video lectures on research methods. Use electronic searches in the University library to find available literature on your topic. The literature may give you good ideas about specific issues you could research, and even provide ideas about research methods you might use. As well as viewing the research methods videos, look at the readings made available to you on aspects of research methodology. When the module officially starts, you will be enrolled on a Dissertation Forum on the RKC website.

Before the module starts, you will be asked to complete and return an online questionnaire about your ideas for a topic, and your ideas for how you want to research it. You will be asked to return this at least two weeks before the module start date. RKC will use this information to identify a suitable supervisor for you. The supervisor will contact you at the start of the module, and you should agree with them about how you will work together (see the section below for more information about working with a supervisor).

You should communicate regularly with your supervisor, and aim to get feedback from them on your Proposal and on drafts of part, or all, of your Dissertation. You should use the RKC Thesis Repository for submitting drafts and getting feedback on them.

At an early stage in the module, you should complete a research ethics audit, using the University research ethics screening checklist, which is on the RKC Online Campus site. All pieces of research carried out for University qualifications must receive research ethics approval. All research ethics forms will be reviewed by your supervisor and by a panel in RKC. Depending on the circumstances, it may be that the supervisor and the panel are able to give approval for your research to proceed. However, some proposed research may need to go to a University committee for scrutiny. It is important to complete the screening form early in the module, so that if scrutiny by committee is necessary there is not too much delay for you in carrying out your research. You should not gather information you are going to use in your research from individuals (such as by carrying out interviews or by issuing questionnaires) until after you have been given research ethics approval.

If you decide to change your plans about what data you will gather, or who you will gather data from, you may need to complete the research ethics audit form a second time.

How do I work with a supervisor?

Your dissertation supervisor should contact you by email once they have agreed with RKC that they will supervise your research. They will have seen your pre-module questionnaire. They will be one of a number of tutors who work for RKC and who have been approved by the University to work as dissertation supervisors on the programmes. Many dissertation supervisors are tutors at other universities.

You should agree with your supervisor how you will work together, including key points such as how you will communicate with each other, how often you will communicate, how much notice the supervisor will need if you ask for feedback on a draft, and so on. You might reach this agreement through email communications, or through Zoom, Teams or Skype, or other methods that you agree between you.

In this module, you need mainly to make your own decisions - the supervisor will not make them for you. You might expect the supervisor to advise, to question, to support, to act as a

sounding board, and to give you feedback on plans and drafts. You should read carefully (or listen carefully to) any feedback.

When you seek feedback on plans or drafts, you should upload your material to the RKC Thesis Repository, and the supervisor should reply to you in the same way. This enables RKC to keep a record of what you have submitted and what replies you have received. You might also use email, or other methods as agreed, for quick communications and updates with your supervisor, but you should keep a note of these.

If you are unhappy with the way things are working out with your supervisor, you should first of all take this up directly with them. If you feel that there is a problem with the relationship between you and your supervisor that you have not been able to resolve through direct discussion, then the next step is to email RKC student care, who will work with you both to resolve the issue. This might involve setting ground rules or some other guidelines which clarify the relationship, or in the case of total mismatch, could result in a reallocation of supervisor.

What do I need to do in order to succeed on the module?

There is no guaranteed formula for success that applies to every research project and every researcher. This section of the paper contains some key tips. More detailed guidance is provided by the Residency sessions, by the video lectures, and by the research methodology readings, and individual guidance will also be provided by your supervisor.

1. Create and maintain a focus for your research, with a clear research question, and clear, realistic research objectives. Keep the question and objectives in mind throughout your research activity. Make sure that your dissertation answers the question and addresses each of the objectives.
2. Keep in mind the requirements of the Proposal and the Dissertation, as set out in the Module Handbook. These will be used by the assessors when they evaluate your work. Make sure you address each of these to the required extent.
3. Explore the available literature on your topic, using the electronic search facilities at the University to identify and download relevant papers. Doing this early in the process may help you to focus your topic, and may also help you decide on a methodology. And a good literature review will be a key part of both your Proposal and your Dissertation. A good literature review will demonstrate an awareness of any recent publications that are relevant to your topic.
4. Explore the resources available on research methodology. When you write your Proposal - and particularly when you write the Dissertation - link your methodology, and your evaluation of it, to relevant literature on research.
5. Leave enough time for your planned methods: in particular, plan ahead for any interviews, focus groups, and for any survey you intend to carry out. Getting into the diaries of busy people in order to interview them is often something that needs a fair amount of forewarning. Designing and issuing a good questionnaire also takes time.
6. Leave yourself time, too, to write and then to review what you have written. The Dissertation can be written in chapters. Much of the literature review, and much of the methodology chapter, can be written before you sit down to analyse and write up your findings. These early chapters may need some amendments and additions at a later stage, but it is usually much easier to edit and change them than it is to write them entirely at this later stage.

7. In the best dissertations, the different chapters fit together in a coherent whole. The research question and objectives are addressed throughout the other chapters. Relevant literature is identified in the literature review. The findings relate to the question and objectives, and to the stated methodology. The analysis brings together the findings and relevant ideas from the literature review. The conclusions and recommendations flow from what has been discussed before. Work towards making the different parts of your dissertation fit together like this. Plan to leave yourself time to review the whole dissertation towards the end of the module, and make sure these connections are evident.
8. Work with your supervisor, as indicated in the previous section. Agree from the beginning how you will work together. Seek feedback from them at appropriate times. Give them time to respond. Read their feedback carefully and act on it.
9. Remember the potential to share ideas with colleagues on the programme, through the Dissertation Forum, or in small groups, or in 1:1 communications. Although you may be working on different topics, you will have in common some of the challenges (as well as the achievements) of carrying out a research process, and it can help if you share and communicate. The Dissertation module can be a lonelier place than the four previous modules, but it is not something that you must go through completely alone.

What happens after I complete the dissertation?

The dissertation is marked by your supervisor and by another tutor nominated by RKC. This marking is carried out independently. An agreed mark is then arrived at between the two tutors.

The dissertation and the markers' comments are then sent to the University, in a batch along with other dissertations completed by that deadline. A sample of the dissertations is moderated by the Module Director, and marks are agreed.

At this point the agreed marks are communicated to you, with the understanding that these are provisional marks only at this stage, until they are formally approved by examination boards within the University. Because of the size of this piece of work, and the marking involved, it may take up to eight weeks for you to receive your mark for the dissertation.

A sample of dissertations is sent to the External Examiners for the programme, and their comments are received. The agreed marks are then presented to an examination board within the Business School of the University. After the marks have been approved at this board, they go the examination board for the whole University, which meets three times a year (usually in February, July and October). When they have been approved by this board, you have officially graduated with a Master's degree, and your certificates and transcripts are prepared.

The University graduation ceremony is usually carried out only once a year (in November) and you will be invited to the next ceremony after you complete the programme. You will, however, have achieved the award of the degree at the point where the university examination board approves your mark for the final piece of work.